The Words You'll Hear About Care Settings and Kinds of Help

Eighteen terms in one plain line each, and what to write down for each.

Her care team has a vocabulary, and the words arrive quickly: assisted living, memory care, skilled nursing, standby help, cueing. Here are eighteen of them. The outside terms are each defined from a public source, and every one comes with what to write down when you hear it.

The definitions are general, and they are for following the conversation. They aren't for working out which word fits your wife.

Kinds of places

Assisted living

A residential living arrangement that provides individualized personal care, help with activities of daily living, help with medications, and services such as laundry and housekeeping. Types and sizes of facilities vary, and so do levels of care and services. [1]

WRITE DOWN Who used the word, and what help they had in mind when they said it.

Memory care

Specialized care for people with cognitive impairments. It may be a free-standing residence or part of an assisted living facility. [2]

WRITE DOWN Who used the word, and what they've seen that brought it up. Ask; don't guess.

Nursing home (skilled nursing facility)

Provides a wide range of health and personal care services, which typically include nursing care, 24-hour supervision, three meals a day and help with everyday activities. [3]

WRITE DOWN Whether anyone on her care team has mentioned it, and what for.

Home-based care

Mostly personal care: help with everyday activities at home. It can be supplemented by paid caregivers, who include nurses, home health care aides and therapists. [4]

WRITE DOWN The help she has at home now, and who gives it.

Kinds of help

Activities of daily living (ADLs)

The basic actions people perform every day: bathing, dressing, transferring (moving to and from a bed or a chair), eating, and caring for incontinence. [1]

WRITE DOWN Which ones she gets help with, and who helps.

Instrumental activities of daily living (IADLs)

Activities needed to live independently: light housework, preparing and cleaning up after meals, taking medication, shopping, using the telephone and managing money. [1]

WRITE DOWN Who does each of these now.

Personal care (custodial care)

Non-skilled help with bathing, dressing, eating, getting in and out of a bed or chair, moving around and using the bathroom. [1]

WRITE DOWN Which of these you help with, and the times of day you've seen it needed.

Skilled care

Nursing care, such as help with medications and caring for wounds, and therapies such as occupational, speech, respiratory and physical therapy. It usually requires a licensed professional such as a nurse, doctor or therapist. [1]

WRITE DOWN Any nursing or therapy her care team says she needs, in their words.

Supervision

The National Institute on Aging describes it as supervision "to make sure a person is safe," and lists it with help with everyday activities as part of personal care at home. [4]

WRITE DOWN What you've seen, written as a question for her care team.

Standby help and cueing

A helper gives verbal cues or a steadying touch while the person does the activity herself. The assessment form that home health clinicians fill in calls this "supervision or touching assistance." [5]

WRITE DOWN The tasks where you remind, prompt or stand close by.

Transferring

Moving to and from a bed or a chair. [1]

WRITE DOWN What she holds or uses, and whether someone helps.

People and process

Discharge planning

The process that determines the kind of care a patient needs after leaving the hospital. Your point person may be a discharge planning manager, a social worker, a nurse or another hospital representative. [6]

WRITE DOWN That person's name and direct phone number.

Care manager (case manager)

A professional, usually with a background in counseling, social work or a related health care field, who is trained to assess a family's situation and to put in place and monitor a care plan. [7]

WRITE DOWN Whether one is involved yet, and their name.

Caregiver

Anyone who helps care for an older person or a person with a disability who lives at home. That includes you. [1]

WRITE DOWN What you do in a day, and what you can realistically keep doing.

Words this roadmap uses

Care requirements

What your wife's next care arrangement has to be able to do for her, written as tasks and kinds of help instead of the name of a place.

WRITE DOWN The tasks, in your own words.

Capability

Something a care arrangement is able to do. It's a thing to ask a provider to verify, not to assume.

WRITE DOWN Each one on your list, as a question to ask.

Essential and preference

An essential is help she can't manage without. A preference would make life better but isn't a must.

WRITE DOWN Two separate lists, with her preferences in her own words. Health, medication and supervision items wait for her care team.

Confirmed and open

Confirmed means her care team has said it or written it down. Open means it's still a question, however sure you feel.

WRITE DOWN Beside each item, which it is, and who confirmed it.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words. It doesn't say which of them apply to your wife, how much help she needs or which kind of place fits. That's for the people who assess her.

Ready for the next step?

You know what the words mean in general and what to write down when you hear one. The care interview is where they become about your wife: it goes through her daily life one area at a time, in plain language, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The first three groups are defined from the sources below. The last group is the Family Care Roadmap's own vocabulary.

1. Administration for Community Living, Glossary
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Residential Care Options: Housing Options
3. National Institute on Aging, Long-Term Care Facilities: Assisted Living, Nursing Homes, and Other Residential Care
4. National Institute on Aging, What Is Long-Term Care?
5. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Outcome and Assessment Information Set Version E1 (OASIS-E1) All Items, effective 01/01/2025
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
7. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources